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Billy Mitchell

The Basie Orchestra always had great tenor sax soloists. Billy Mitchell continued that tradition with his two tours of duty with Basie. Born in Kansas City in 1926, he found his first professional work in Detroit with Nat Towles, later playing with Lucky Millinder's band and moving to New York in the late 40s. His big band work continued with Milt Buckner, Gil Fuller and Woody Herman. Billy worked with Basie from 1957-61 and he returned in 1966. In the interim he co-led a quintet with fellow Baseite Al Grey and worked in Europe with the Clarke-Boland Big Band. His work is well represented on Basie recordings and with small groups, including the Xanadu All Stars.

Billy was interviewed by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, in New York on November 16, 1995.

MR: We are here today filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and it's our great pleasure to have with us saxophonist Billy Mitchell. Welcome.

BM: Thank you.

MR: You just told me you were born at an early age — I hate to steal your line, it was a good one. Tell me about where you grew up.

BM: I grew up in Detroit. I was born in Kansas City. We moved to Detroit when I was two years old and I grew up there.

MR: Was Detroit a city that had a good deal of music going on in it?

BM: Yes. One of the most. It was a tremendous amount of jazz music in Detroit at that time. There were so many clubs, oh, that was before we hit the "great white jackpot."

MR: Great white jackpot?

BM: Yeah. That was before let's say Lionel Hampton played the Paramount. I think that's where the breakthrough was. But in those days you had all kinds of black and tan clubs and every little club had a band and a singer and a shake dancer and a master of ceremonies. There were maybe four or five within a two block span you know? There was a lot of music going on there, and that was in the late 30s and early 40s.

MR: What brought you to the saxophone?

BM: I think I wanted to lead a band. I think I wanted to lead a band. I used to listen to music on the radio. I remember in particular I think it was Benny Goodman's "Camel Caravan." And I think I wanted a clarinet because he stood in front of the band and played all the solos. It didn't work out that way though.

MR: Did you take lessons in school or was it—

BM: Yeah, I started in the public school system, and about I guess I was around the sixth grade, something like that.

MR: Nat Towles was a big band at the time?

BM: Well Nat Towles was, well see in that time there were also a lot of territory bands. Nat Towles was in the midwest, based in Omaha. There were other bands like Snookum Russell in Cincinnati, Lloyd Hunter in Iowa, and oh there were so many, oh there were so many. But all that's gone now. You know those were the so-called territory bands you see.

MR: Can you explain that for the folks that might not be familiar with that term?

BM: Which term?

MR: The territory bands.

BM: Well, they worked out of a certain territory, and usually within a certain radius. Like Towles, he was based in Omaha and he played all over Nebraska, Iowa and also the south. All bands went south at that time because all music was mostly big band music, and it was for dancing, you know, for dances. So a territory band was more or less meant that a band's headquarters was in a particular — in Towles' case it was midwest; in others it was south, or wherever you happened to be.

MR: How large a group was that, and was it, in the playing of it did you have to play a lot by ear or was there music written out for you in that group?

BM: It was music written out. All the same people who are doing the arranging today. Oh well not – you know, many of them aren't left. But we were playing arrangements for like Bill Davis, he's the one that wrote the "April in Paris" for Basie, and the organ player, we were playing his music. There were arrangements. Of course you always played by ear though. Music is what you hear.

MR: A lot of the fellows at that time seemed to also go through Lucky Millinder's band?

BM: I came to New York in Lucky Millinder's band. 1948. I stayed in Lucky's band two weeks, I got fired, and then I went back. Oh, the reason he fired me is 'cause I had on a pair of black trousers instead of tuxedo pants. So I stayed there about I guess two more months and then, who did I go with then, I think it was Lunceford's band. They were making a memorial tour. And that was the era where you had to have two tenor saxophones, battling as part of the showmanship. And their band wasn't set up that way. They had two altos, and only one tenor. And they didn't have time to have the book translated, so I got the gig 'cause I could translate the alto parts.

MR: Oh — that's a tricky transposition.

BM: Not really.

MR: Well that's good.

BM: Especially after you do it a little while.

MR: Who did you have to battle against?

BM: Joe Thomas. Yeah he was a legend. He was my roommate too. It was kind of nice having him for a roommate. See I was young. I was 21. It was my first time out, but Joe had been out for years. So he knew everyone, everywhere. So in those days you shared rooms. So wherever we went he always knew someone who invited him to stay with them so I always had a room to myself.

MR: That's nice. It made it a little bit easier.

BM: Yeah.

MR: What was it like being on the road in that time? Was it different when you went from one part of the country to the other going from north to south?

BM: Yeah. Well yes there's a difference. But you find adverse conditions shall we say, anywhere. You know the geographical locations didn't necessarily dictate to what the social or accepted mores of the community might be you know.

MR: And the majority of the gigs that you played were for dances still at that time? It seems like dancing was a very big part of jazz music at that time.

BM: The two were inseparable.

MR: What happened after — did you go back to Detroit and play with the Jones?

BM: No, the Jones played with me.

MR: All right.

BM: I came here in '48. I worked with Lucky and Lunceford, and then I think Milton Butler's big band, and then Walter Fuller, who had been Dizzy's arranger and in his band. And then I left here and my father died, and I went back to Detroit in February of '49. And then I left there when I went to join Woody Herman somewhere in September or October of '49 or something like that. And I stayed out there a couple of months with Woody Herman. Then I came back to Detroit and started a band at a place called Blue Bird Inn there. Well I didn't start the band. As a matter of fact I went in there working with someone else, but eventually it became my band. And then Thad Jones and Elvin Jones and Tommy Flanagan came in after that, a few years or so something like that.

MR: Those were all Detroit-area people?

BM: Yes. Say Detroit area. Because the Jones' were from Pontiac but that's like 28 miles or something like that, out of Detroit.

MR: How did your career with the Basie band come about?

BM: Lockjaw came by one day and said, "Hey man, Basie wants to talk to you." And then about a week later Ernie Wilkins came by and said, "Hey man, Basie wants to talk to you." It was the only way you'd get a job in music is somebody that's already in the band, when there comes an opening, naturally they recommend someone, so they'd say, "Bas' I got somebody for you." I don't know exactly who recommended me to Basie. I'd always thought maybe it could have been Thad or it could have been Frank Foster you

know. Because I had been associated with them most recently in Detroit. Years later, I think Joe Newman told me it was he that recommended me to Basie, but I don't really know.

MR: Did you enjoy playing with that group?

BM: Basie's men?

MR: Yes.

BM: Of course. It was the band in the land. It was a great band, one of the greatest. And the respect that you get, was enormous. They were at the top of the heap at the time because Basie and Duke was the only people that really kept steady bands at that time. The rest of the bands would, for example Woody Herman or Stan Kenton, they would organize to make a tour, and then when the tour was over, this band would disband. But Basie stayed active all year around.

MR: Let's see, at that time Marshall Royal —

BM: Was concertmaster of the band.

MR: A very important figure in the Basie group at that time.

BM: Very important figure anywhere.

MR: Who was your other tenor player? Eric Dixon at that time?

BM: No. Eric came in after me. Frank Wess and Frank Foster. Frank alternated playing tenor/alto, whichever one he had in his hand that's the one he played. In fact I did it once you get used to it you know. So sometimes, rather than change horns, he would just play his part on whichever horn he had. So whatever struck him. If he felt like playing the third alto part, he'd play it on the alto. If he already had the tenor in his hand, he'd play it on tenor. The saxophone section was Charlie Fowlkes on baritone, Frank Wess playing alto and tenor, Frank Foster and myself playing tenor, and Marshall of course.

MR: There certainly was something about the rhythm section in Basie's group that made it distinctive. Was it enjoyable to play over that rhythm section for the soloists?

BM: It's enjoyable to play with any good rhythm section. Don't you enjoy playing with a good rhythm section? Well that was a good rhythm section.

MR: Yeah it sure was. What made it that way?

BM: What made what what way?

MR: Have a distinctive sound that made that group seem to be so smooth?

BM: I don't think I understand what you mean. What ingredients made it better?

MR: Yeah.

BM: What do you think made it that way?

MR: Well I think it may have come from the fact that Basie played so economically that the rhythm section had a lot of space to it, and it just seemed to be really light I guess. Maybe they were keeping in mind the dancers, too at the time. How did the saxophone, how did

you decide who got the solo space? Was that from the arranger's standpoint, or did Basie kind of indicate who he wanted to play on what tunes?

BM: Well the chair has certain solos that are built into it. You know, like if you come in the band and this particular tune had the solo for your chair then you played it. Somebody would tell you, hey man, this is your chorus. So that's all there was to that.

MR: Was Joe Williams still performing occasionally with the group at that time?

BM: He was in the group as a permanent member at that time. I'm trying to recall who was it that left first, was it Joe or myself. But we left within a couple of months of each other. Either he or I was first. I think maybe it was myself. And I left in '61. I think he was still there then. But the last week that I worked with the band, we worked with Tony Bennett at the place in Jersey, what's the name of it, Lantasina or Latin Quarter or something like that. So I don't think Joe was singing that week, because naturally Tony Bennett was the featured attraction. So I may have left Joe there. I think he was still in the band when I left. I think I was the first one to leave.

MR: You certainly played behind some great singers over the years, with Tony, and of course earlier on.

BM: All of them. We recorded with everybody. At that time everybody wanted to record with the Basie band because the musicianship was so high and then the band itself was moving, so record companies always wanted to try to put two salable commodities together if they could. So everybody wanted to record with us. Just about every singer of the day — King Cole, Johnny Mathis, Ella, Sarah, Tony, Frank, oh and there's some more in there. That's one of the advantages of the job. It really wasn't that much in salary, but we did rather well because we had so many outside things — the television shows, we did all the shows, and so that made the job really a little more lucrative than it would have been otherwise. The salaries were no great amount of money.

MR: And did you get to travel overseas with Basie?

BM: Yeah. I went to Europe with Basie in '59 I think. But I'd been around the world with Dizzy's band before that.

MR: Yeah. It was a State Department tour? Is that what that was?

BM: Yeah.

MR: That must have been really something.

BM: That was a nice trip because it wasn't hurried or rushed. We spent anywhere from 10 days to 2 weeks almost in each place. So it was a chance to observe some of the cultures in the different places, like the first stop was Abadan, Iran. And that's a big change from New York.

MR: How did they accept the music?

BM: Everywhere jazz is well accepted because it's a rarity. For them it was a rarity to experience the original and authentic music. The reception was great everywhere but that has changed over the years too. I'm one of those who thinks that jazz ain't dead but it's low sick.

MR: Why? Why do you feel that way?

BM: Why do I feel that way? Because I look around me. I don't see any jazz. I don't see any clubs. I don't see any — don't you feel that way?

MR: Well I think there's a certain smaller group of people that are keeping it alive.

BM: Yeah. It's low sick.

MR: Low sick. Yeah there's certainly not the opportunities for young players to learn like they used to I guess. You had a few years in between with Basie. You left and came back?

BM: Well, no it's not really going back. I would go like if someone asked. For example Eric's mother was ill so he had to take off, so I'd fill in for him for a couple of weeks. And one time Lockjaw had, but it wasn't really like I went back to the band, I was just holding the chair until these people got back.

MR: What was it like to play, didn't you play in Europe with the Clarke-Boland Big Band? Was their conception, the way they play big band music any different from here in the states?

BM: Their conception? You have to break it down. What do you mean by their conception?

MR: The European approach to jazz music. Was it different at all or did they really just reflect what was going on in the states? They must have learned it from listening to records too.

BM: I find that a tough one. Music, jazz music or any other kind of music, is a calling. And I don't think that there is any particular bent caused by geographic location. No I thought that was, and after all so many of the members after all were American jazz musicians. In the band with me was Sahib Shibab, Billy Bailey, Idrees Sulieman, Kenny Clarke, Nat Peck, these are all American musicians. I couldn't analyze their conception by the geography.

MR: Were you ever tempted to stay in Europe like some of those other fellows?

BM: No.

MR: And you ended up here in the New York area. You've been here for quite a while, right? I notice you are playing a gig pretty soon as part of, on the Island I think, is it Sunday, you're playing with —

BM: Yes. This is an affair to benefit musicians who don't have proper medical insurance and things like that. The Jazz Foundation of America I think they're called. I don't know too much about them, but I did say that I would take part in that particular concert.

MR: How often are you playing these days? Enough to keep you happy?

BM: Yeah. I go to Europe two or three or four times a year, depending on what the circumstances are. I don't come in to New York.

MR: When you go to Europe, are you able to pick the people you're going to go with? Or is it sometimes the type of thing where you go over there as a soloist and play with a rhythm section over there.

BM: There are all kinds of situations. All types of situations. Each one is an individual thing. It depends on what the rules of the house are. They want you to bring your own group or they want you to come. Their program may be for like, a lot of them have been like Basie related type things, and they call them everything from Basie's alumni to the Count's Men and the One O'clock Jumpers. And there are other things where I go and I'm just featured with a particular group, and then there are other things where I go and I take my own group. Each event is individual.

MR: What kind of band leader was Basie? Was he easy to work for?

BM: Yeah. He was easy to work for.

MR: Him and Ellington seemed to have very different styles of leading a group from what I've heard.

BM: I wouldn't know. I never worked with the Duke's band.

MR: Who were some of your favorite arrangers for the Basie group at the time?

BM: Well my favorite arrangers for the Basie group at the time were the ones that were in the band. Although Basie never recorded a full album of their work, or he may have, I think he did. I think the one for Frank, Chairman of the Board, that was all of Frank Foster's. But I thought that the best writers for the band were the members: Frank Foster, Ernie Wilkins and Thad Jones and later on Eric. But like I say, Eric came after me. When I left I think Budd Johnson took my place, and then I think it was Eric and then Jimmy Forrest, I don't remember.

MR: Do you think it's because those guys knew exactly what went well in the band, because they were right in the middle of it so they could write more effectively?

BM: Yeah. They could write for the people in the band. Like when one of them wrote something, he envisioned, he knew the capabilities of the person he was writing it for. I've seen, to give you an example, we had a rehearsal one time in Chicago, and Nelson Riddle brought in material for an album. And we rehearsed it and ran it down, and naturally the first time with things like that, Nelson was listening and thinking about some things he could change. And then Marshall said, "Thad did you say you had something?" And Thad said, "Yeah." So Thad passed out his arrangement. And from the first note, it was just — and Nelson sat there and listened and when it was over he looked at Bas' and he collected his music and he said, "I think I'll go back and try again."

MR: No kidding.

BM: There's nothing unusual about that.

MR: What was the basic rhythm section while you were in the group?

BM: Eddie Jones, Bas', Sonny Payne and Freddie Green.

MR: Freddie was certainly an important part of that.

BM: Sweetest cat that ever lived.

MR: "Pep" they call him.

BM: He was a very easy going type of person. Very level. Of course he could, if he did get upset it was kind of fun to see.

MR: He would wait and choose his moments, huh?

BM: Yeah.

MR: When you were, after you left the Basie band you worked mostly with small groups?

BM: After I left the Basie band I was fixing pool tables. 'Cause when anybody would see me on the street they'd say, "Hey man, I didn't know the band was in town." When I left the Basie band I'd been in big bands for five years so all contacts and things here — so when I left the band I put on a pair of overalls. That didn't last long.

MR: Would you suggest to young players that they try to make their living in music these days?

BM: Would you?

MR: Well, probably not.

BM: Well I'm not going to give you any argument on that. But you know as crowded as the field may be, and as sparse as opportunities may be, I think it's pretty much, there's always room for the best.

MR: If people really have it in their blood, you know, I don't think there's any denying it.

BM: Well that's it. You don't play music because you necessarily want to. You, when I say "play music" I mean you don't follow a musician's life and lifestyle unless you really have to. You can't do anything else.

MR: Someone said it's like a, almost like an illness. You can't get rid of it. A positive illness I hope.

BM: I like to say it's a calling.

MR: That's a good way to put it. What do you listen to at home? Do you have certain tastes in music?

BM: I like great music.

MR: Great music. All kinds then.

BM: I like great music.

MR: Okay. Can you remember recording these records? It's interesting that Basie —

BM: Yes and no. I can remember, one of these dates I can remember the studio and Ralph Sharon sitting at the studio. But like I say it doesn't say here what year this was. Some of

them I remember and some of them I don't. A lot of times you see something and you say who is that? What is that? And they say, "Hey, that's you man, just at such and such a time." "Oh yeah, no kidding?" That happens.

MR: Yeah. When you were in the studio and recording, and if you had a tenor solo and you didn't like what you played, did you ever get a chance to do it again or was it pretty much they had to—

BM: Well if you didn't like something, you might say, "Let's try that again I think I can do better with it." But then you'd keep what was done before and maybe you'd do better with it and then sometimes somebody will say, "Well try it again man you can do better with it." And man I says, "No, let it go." Depends on the time.

MR: You did some playing with Al Grey after the Basie band, is that right?

BM: Yeah, we had a small group together. I first met Al way back in that Lucky Millinder band in '48. And then after we had both left Basie's band we had a sextet for a small time a couple of years, Dave Burns, Bobby Hutcherson, Herman Wright, Candy Finch and Al and myself.

MR: Who would handle the business for a group like that?

BM: I did.

MR: Was that a hard task?

BM: Terrible. When you've got a band you become mother, father, priest, laundry ticket holder, banker. You want to lead a band?

MR: No.

BM: Got out of that one quick.

MR: Well the business of music, yeah, I mean that's much harder than the actual playing of it I would think.

BM: Well I'll tell you about the business. You know who gets the money? Whoever gets his hands on it first. And that's the way that goes.

MR: Do you listen to any young players that you think are good for the future of jazz?

BM: You mean just purposefully set out to listen to young players to see what's good for jazz or am I listening to the radio and I hear somebody.

MR: Yeah. I mean do you hear somebody every once in a while that you think is kind of —

BM: Oh, I hear a lot of people that are quite promising that are young people, and you wonder which direction they'll go. I've heard a lot that they were just marvelous youngsters, but ten years later you say "what ever became of —" So it's not, you know, it takes I always like to say it takes you twenty-five years to learn and then five or six years to learn what to leave out. There's a lot of the youngsters get caught up in the proficiency and the musicality and they forget the emotion. And the emotion takes longer to, you have to experience it. You can't work with somebody like Dizzy Gillespie without learning

something if you've got your eyes open. His complete appeal wasn't only in what he was playing, it was how he was presenting. Presentation is so important. And that's the thing that you don't learn at the same time you're learning to play the instrument. So many of the, not only youngsters, many people, they get caught up in the musicality like I say, and there is no emotion there. So it's a balancing of the two. The only time, you know, in other words yeah, there are a lot of guys that you hear and say, "Oh, wow, isn't he marvelous, and he's only eighteen years old." Okay now let me hear him when he's 38.

MR: So he's playing a little more, you want to hear a little more experience behind what he's playing and playing more from life than from—

BM: Well I don't make those judgments. I don't try to analyze what I hear. I don't think music has to be explained in grammatical terms. I'm not caught up in that. I don't listen to somebody and say oh man, he plays too much of that or he don't do enough of this. I don't bother with that. I like great music. If I hear something, that was great. And that's the end of it. I'll leave that to the journalists and the archivists.

MR: Maybe the people that don't play often times are the ones that come up with ways to explain things I guess. Anything you'd like to add about your views on music or where you think it's going in the future?

BM: No I really don't give that much thought. I mean where is it going in the future? Who knows? You mean should we spend time in speculating? Well I think maybe it's going to be that everybody's going to start playing songs. I never think about those things.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your time, and it's been a great pleasure talking to Billy Mitchell, who is a great saxophonist—

BM: Well thank you.

MR: And a former member of a lot of wonderful bands, and I hope you have a great gig this weekend, and thanks for your time.

BM: Will you be in town?

MR: We will not be in town unfortunately.

BM: What a pity, what a pity, what a pity, what a pity. You could come out for and partake and contribute.

MR: We'll be back. So next time we'll call you up and see where you're playing and see if we can coordinate it.

BM: Well let me wish you a lot of luck on your endeavor. I certainly think it's a worthwhile project and I hope you will be able to find some people who might be a little more enlightening.

MR: No I like your basic outlook on music, I mean it's very refreshing you know, the idea of great music.

BM: Yeah that's it. Either you like it or you don't. No sense in trying to take it apart and see what it is, unless you're writing an article.

MR: Okay. Well on behalf of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, thank you very much.

BM: Thank you.